Qollab × IonQ Hackathon: Participant Plan

48 hours, Oct 9 at 7:00 PM ET to Oct 11 at 7:00 PM ET. Build an open source quantum project with Qiskit, run it on IonQ's quantum simulator, and publish it on Qollab.xyz. No quantum experience required; some Python familiarity helps. You register under one university "node" for a local Slack channel, a site lead, and local judges, and you also compete globally.

Key dates (Eastern Time)

Date	Milestone
Sept 28, 11:00 AM	Registration opens at qollab.xyz
Sept 29, 1:00 PM to 2:00 PM	Live Student AMA (optional, recorded)
Oct 6, 11:00 AM	Registration closes
Oct 9, 7:00 PM to Oct 11, 7:00 PM	Build window: kickoff to submission deadline. Mentor hours run Oct 10 to Oct 11
Week of Oct 12	Local judging at your node
Week of Oct 19	Global judging; all winners announced; certificates and badges follow

Kickoff and deadline in your time zone

Location	Kickoff (Fri Oct 9)	Deadline (Sun Oct 11)
Los Angeles / Vancouver (PDT)	4:00 PM	4:00 PM
Calgary / Denver (MDT)	5:00 PM	5:00 PM
Bogota / Medellin (COT)	6:00 PM	6:00 PM
New York / Toronto / Atlanta (EDT)	7:00 PM	7:00 PM
Halifax (ADT) / Buenos Aires (ART)	8:00 PM	8:00 PM
Lisbon (WEST)	Sat 12:00 AM	Mon 12:00 AM
Barcelona / Bratislava (CEST)	Sat 1:00 AM	Mon 1:00 AM
Riga / Helsinki (EEST)	Sat 2:00 AM	Mon 2:00 AM
India (IST)	Sat 4:30 AM	Mon 4:30 AM

Eligibility and teams

Rule	Details
Age and team size	18 or older. Solo, or a team of 2 to 4, at the same node and in the same category (student and professional teams not yet supported)
Students	Enrolled at a participating node
Professionals	Any node near you or one you're affiliated with; not near one, register as a professional under the closest node
Multiple projects	Allowed. Awards go per project, not per person or team
Teaming up across schools	Register under the professional track

Eligible countries (44): Argentina, Australia, Austria, Belgium, Brazil, Bulgaria, Canada, Chile, Colombia, Cyprus, Czechia, Denmark, Estonia, Finland, France, Germany, Greece, Hungary, India, Indonesia, Ireland, Israel, Italy, Japan, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malaysia, Malta, Mexico, Netherlands, New Zealand, Norway, Poland, Portugal, Romania, Singapore, Slovakia, South Korea, Spain, Sweden, Switzerland, United Kingdom, United States. Not listed? Email hello@qollab.xyz; a small number of additional requests are still under review.

Getting ready

☐ Create an account at qollab.xyz. This is also your access to IonQ's simulator; no separate IonQ account, API key, or IonQ Cloud account needed
☐ Register under one node before Oct 6, 11:00 AM ET, then join your node's Slack channel and #hackathon-help from the invite you receive
☐ Attend the AMA, Tuesday, Sept 29, 1:00 PM to 2:00 PM ET, or watch the recording afterward
☐ Read the Terms and FAQ on the hackathon website, and install Qiskit locally if you want to test setup ahead of time
☐ Choose a theme (optional) and brainstorm. You can plan, but not build, before kickoff
☐ Look for the walkthrough and rules Q&A session in the week before kickoff; details in Slack

Themes and what to build

Themes are optional. Any project can win 1st, 2nd, or 3rd place; only a themed project can win a theme specialty award. Use what makes quantum computing unique, not just a random number generator.

Theme	The challenge
Quantum Impact	Solve a real world problem with a hybrid quantum and classical approach. Build a strong classical baseline, then show where a quantum subroutine improves solution quality, efficiency, or accuracy.
Quantum Playground	Build something playful, artistic, or unexpected, such as a game, music, art, or an interactive experience where superposition, interference, entanglement, or measurement is essential.
Quantum Unlocked	Make a hard quantum concept click through an interactive demo, animation, or visualization, such as error correction, fault tolerance, quantum networking, or a specific algorithm.

Every submission must show at least one of: a novel application of an existing technique to a new domain, a technical extension (noise or error mitigation, optimization, benchmarking), or an original analytical or educational contribution. Missing this bar can mean a 0 on Novelty and Technical Execution.

Submission requirements

Published and runnable on Qollab.xyz by Oct 11, 7:00 PM ET, for every node at the same moment. Can't finish? Submit what you have; partial projects are still eligible.

☐ Built with the Qiskit framework
☐ Runs without any errors on the quantum simulator available through Qollab (for Quantum Impact theme)
☐ Published and runnable on Qollab.xyz under an MIT license
☐ A Qollab project page explaining what the project does, the problem it explores, how to run it, and enough detail for others to replicate or extend it
☐ Built during the build window (projects that already existed, prior coursework, and work started before kickoff are not eligible)
☐ Follows industry best practices on UI accessibility
☐ A written summary covering each judging criterion: novelty, technical execution, impact, and documentation
☐ Attribution line: "This effort is supported by Qollab & IonQ."
☐ Disclosure of any external libraries, templates, or outside code the project builds on, and confirmation the team is licensed to use them
☐ A theme tag: Quantum Impact, Quantum Playground, or Quantum Unlocked (required only for theme awards)
☐ A short demo video (not scored on production quality)
☐ A code repository link

Before the deadline: open your published project from a logged out browser or a teammate's account, and check that it runs start to finish.

Judging, prizes and rules

Two rounds, same four criteria. Your node's 3 local judges score every submission first; a global panel scores the top 3 from each node, plus up to one project per specialty category, a second time.

Criterion	What judges look for
Novelty and Creativity	An original idea or approach, not a standard

	tutorial or well known demo
Technical Execution	Correct, well built code that runs and does what it claims
Impact Potential	Whether it could matter beyond the hackathon, for research, education, industry, or the community
Documentation Quality	Whether others can understand, run, replicate, and extend it

	1st	2nd	3rd	Specialty
Local (10+ submissions): cash / credits	$500 / $5,000	$300 / $3,000	$200 / $2,000	N/A
Global: cash / credits	$10,000 / $20,000	$5,000 / $15,000	$2,500 / $10,000	$500 / $5,000

Specialty awards: Most Novel/Creative, Best of each theme, Most Impact, Best Documentation; a project can win both a placement and a specialty award. Select teams may also get mentorship sessions, sponsor interviews, or extra credits. Nodes may add local prizes such as course credit.

Rules to know:

- Using AI tools, open source libraries, tutorials, or Qollab templates is fine, as long as you disclose and attribute them.
- Disqualifiable: work that already existed, uncredited copying, an undisclosed template, a nearly identical submission to another team's, or misrepresented authorship.
- Standard code of conduct applies; your site lead enforces it locally.
- By participating you agree to: MIT license, keeping the project live on Qollab for 12 months, the attribution line, a valid payment method if you win, and, if you win, being featured by Qollab and IonQ, handling your own taxes on the award, and one social post about participating.
- Scores and awards are final, except disqualification, appealable to hackathon@qollab.xyz within 24 hours; a separate reviewer decides within 5 business days.

Support and where to get help

Need help with...	Where
Teams, local logistics, in person plans	Your node's Slack channel or your site lead
Account, registration, submission, platform bugs, or simulator errors	#hackathon-help; typical reply time is 1 hour (IonQ loops in on simulator issues)
Quantum or project advice	Mentor office hours, Oct 10 to Oct 11, in 1 hour windows (ET); schedule shared in Slack, some mentors also answer asynchronously
Country eligibility, privacy, general questions	hello@qollab.xyz
Disqualification appeal	hackathon@qollab.xyz, within 24 hours

If the platform goes down, we'll post updates in #hackathon-help. An outage over 12 hours during the build window may mean an extended deadline for all nodes, or late submissions accepted with a short impact note. Short or intermittent issues, and problems limited to your own setup, don't qualify for an extension. Tip: test locally where you can, to stay off the shared simulator queue while debugging.

A couple more things: your data is used only to run the hackathon and the Qollab platform, per the privacy policy at qollab.xyz/privacy. Multiple submissions are fine; each is judged on its own, and the project stays live and forkable on Qollab for at least 12 months either way.